Zine Assignment Overview

A bit about Zines and Feminism

Zines have historically played an important role in injecting lesser heard voices in major social movements, especially in the history of feminist thought. The suffrage movement distributed zines to spread information about voting rights, sex equality, and women's health. As independent publications, zines empowered women often marginalized from the dominant discourse in the feminist movement to challenge and broaden feminist issues to include their lived experiences. These insights from the margins directly precipitated Third Wave Feminism and the movement's progression towards intersectionality. For more on the history of zines and feminism, check out LCC Zine Collection.

The **Zine Assignment** is a class collaboration to produce a philosophical "toolkit" for reflecting on and articulating real-world feminist problems. The goal of this assignment is to bridge theory and practice by critically reflecting on some aspect of the course material and linking it to a personal lived experience, or some concrete current issue, or real-world example.

In **PART I** you will select and present the philosophical "tools" for this toolkit, by presenting an exposition and explanation of a framework of your choice for analyzing feminist problems. This exposition is assessed as a short 2-3 page paper. Since it should be accessible to an audience outside of this class, your prose should try to explain philosophical ideas in clear and simple terms.

In **PART II** you will demonstrate how to use this "philosophical tool," by applying it to articulate a real-world problem, concern or experience. The format for this part of the assignment is broad, and you can be creative in selecting an example and format that interests you.

Important:

1. The topic you choose should be one you are comfortable sharing, as this will go into a zine for everyone in the class, with a digital version available for reprint/ distribution.
2. Be respectful. Criticisms should not personally target individuals. This course has emphasized the feminist insight that oppression is structural and the proper target should be to illuminate oppressive structures with the aim of deconstructing them.

PART I: EXPOSITION

Summary of PART I: of your Zine Project is an expository assignment. This has **two parts.** **Part A:** Articulate and explain 1-2 key ideas(s) of **structural oppression (A)** from one of the following authors: Marilyn Frye, Peggy McIntosh, Iris Marion Young, Kimberlé Crenshaw, or Trina Grillo. Then, in **Part B,** connect these key ideas of structural oppression to **specifically gender-based forms of structural oppression (B)** discussed by one of the following authors: Cudd & Jones, Sandra Bartky, Audre Lorde, Patricia Hill Collins, or Robin Zheng.

Format: 1000-1300 words/3 pages, Times New Roman font, double-spaced, 1-inch margins, sources cited (APA, MLA, Chicago).

Due: Friday, 5/10/24

Part A

Select one of reading that advances revised frameworks for thinking generally about structural oppression: Marilyn Frye, Peggy McIntosh, Iris Marion Young, Kimberlé Crenshaw, or Trina Grillo.

2. Each author thinks that there is a problem with the way we are used to talking and thinking about the concept of oppression. Articulate what the author thinks is limiting the way we think about oppression, and how they aim to revise that conception.
3. Identify, define and explain what you take to be the most striking and useful concepts or categories for addressing the limitations identified by the author. How does this set of concepts advance our understanding of oppression as structural?

Part B

Each of the following authors are concerned with aspects of **gender-based oppression:** Cudd & Jones, Sandra Bartky, Audre Lorde, or Patricia Hill Collins. Select one article by one of these authors, and extend the framework and ideas you lay out in **Part A** to explain and analyze a form of gender-based oppression from one of the articles for **Part B.**

In making your selection, keep in mind that the conceptual "tools" for thinking about gender-based oppression which you present in Part I will eventually be used to analyze a real-world feminist problem of your choice in Part II of the Zine assignment, so make sure you have some idea of how you might want to use the conceptual tools you lay out in this exposition.

PART II: PRAXIS/APPLICATION

In **PART II** you will demonstrate how to use the philosophical tool you presented in **PART I**, by applying it to articulate a real-world problem, concern or experience. The format for this part of the assignment is broad, and you can be creative in selecting an example that interests you.

IMPORTANT:

1. The topic you choose should be one you are comfortable sharing, as this will go into a zine for everyone in the class, with a digital version available for reprint/ distribution.
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Here are just some possibilities for format:

1. Script - Have you ever found yourself in a conversation or debate with someone and realized only afterwards what you should have said? A script for rewriting that conversation might be the format for you! The intended audience could range from a challenger, or someone who is a skeptic about sexism (see Cudd & Jones discussion of objections).
2. Similarly, you could engage in the kind of Socratic Method that we find in Plato's works. You can imagine objections from a skeptic, challenger, or interlocutor and respond to those objections. Or you could focus on getting clear on a mushy idea that everyone uses but is not well understood. [Think Socrates' discussion of what is the good in *The Republic*. Multiple characters come forward to advance a common sense version of their conception of the good life. You could do that with ideas like 'sexism', 'exploitation', 'intersectionality' etc.]
3. Images/Figures - In the intersectionality unit, we consider how images can be "controlling." You may want to assemble a collection of images for analysis according to reflection using the tools for thinking about representation, stereotypes etc. offered by Patricia Hill Collins and Robin Zheng as instances of the kind of cultural imperialism that Iris Marion Young identifies.
4. A toolkit for allies- If you want to provide resources for allies and model a respectful investigation of oppression for those who are interested in addressing their complicity in gender-based oppression, you could unpack your own knapsack of privilege to "calling-in" fellow allies. As McIntosh shows, modeling the unpacking of one's knapsack of privilege can generate community around the practice, and disarm the self-defenses that make confronting one's own privilege feel threatening. It may even mitigate the kinds of "risks" that Cudd & Jones argue men must take on to recognize sexism.